

A Psalm of Freedom

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Behold, a rest from labor has been given.
My students turn to their examinations,
And they desired to prepare for them alone.
So a holiday was given unto me.
Three days.
Today, and tomorrow, and the day after.
A rest from the epsilons and the sigmas;
A release from the toil of calculus.
I chose to honor the morning with slumber,
Sleeping overtime, until I felt good.
And when I rose, I listened to an audio summary of a book.
It should not have felt so good, but it did.
For me, it did.
On this day, the first of my freedom.
My bank account held but one hundred rupees,
For my wealth is not idle; I save and invest
In the share market and other instruments of money.
I live in the Indo-Portuguese land of Goa.
But what had made my spirit feel most alive?
I went forth and purchased a Pepsi, for twenty rupees.
Then I went to the liquor store,
And bought a packet of cheap local port wine, for twenty-five rupees.
I went to a common place of discretion,
Behind a restaurant, where most people do not come.
There, in the sunlight, I drank the Pepsi slowly.
And when it was empty, I filled the bottle with wine.
I discarded the packet in the public dustbin nearby.
I walked to the public park, confident,
My Pepsi bottle filled with wine,
Looking only like Pepsi to the world.
It is not illegal to have alcohol in Goa,
But I did not wish to make it obvious.
So I disguised it.
And that is when I felt it.
When I felt truly alive, and truly happy.
As if I had won a great victory;
As if I had tasted true freedom.

It was half past two in the afternoon.
I sat in the public park and began to sip my wine.
No one was there.
And I could not help but feel powerful.
I could not help but feel free.
One or two ants ran upon my body,
From the public chair in the park.
I sat in the sunlight.
My clothes were minimalist;
My tummy was popping out.
I could not feel anymore alive.

I watched the dragonflies,
Fluttering in the light upon the park,
While I sat under a tree, in the shade, in the same park.
There were holes in my shirt,
Small holes from my house cat,
Who scratched it while I carried him.
I sat with my messy hair, and my spectacles on.
I was a huge mess.
But the absolute power I felt.
Was undeniable, and so was the freedom.
I love to pretend to be a wild man,
Like John the Baptist in the wilderness.
I love to walk outside in the bare minimum of a t-shirt and shorts
Of what you can call clothed, and just fool around.
The alcohol began to kick in.
I felt super loose. I felt free.
Like a man floating in the ocean.
The only thing that could make it better
Was a KFC double decker zinger burger, and some fries.
I could not afford it.
But I have chicken at home. I am not impoverished.
I just desired to stroll outside in the sun.

And as the alcoholic euphoria bloomed,
My mother called me on the phone,
Asking if I was coming for lunch.
I was still sitting in the park,
Like an absolute vagabond.
And I could not feel possibly better,
Even if the whole world was judging me.
There was something awfully amazing
About not trying to fit in.
About rebelling against the status quo.
About potentially stirring up controversy.
I had the freedom to be reckless,
At least for today.
And it felt holy.
It reminded me of the scripture, from Matthew,
Where people judge the Son of Man, saying:
"Behold, he has arrived,
A Glutton and a drunkard,
A friend of tax collectors and social outcasts."
And as I thought of that,
I, who am the entire opposite of a god in that moment,
I could not feel anymore divinely powerful.
The only thing I felt, at that absolute moment,
Was a divine peace.
I felt like a divine mess.
Tranquility. Satisfaction. And freedom.
I thought: there is no other way I would have spent this day.
The wine warmed me on the inside;
The sun warmed me on the outside.
I felt as though the Father Almighty
Had given me a divine embrace with His hands.
I do not think any amount of money
Could replace this feeling.

I took off my glasses.

I looked at the scenery, at the vegetation.
It was all so blurry.
But everything felt so clear.
I did not wear a watch.
Not because I do not have one.
I have watches as expensive as motorcycles, and as cars.
I just sat on the public park chair.
A messy shirt with cat-scratched-holes.
Messy hair.
Loose shorts.
Some dirty sandals.
The hair on my legs sprouted out,
Feeling the sun, like an old grandfather on the beach.
My tummy popped out, from a lack of intense exercise,
From binge eating.
A couch potato, built during the lockdown of Covid-19.
A crooked spine,
From having studied advanced engineering and mathematics for so many years.
This is what I truly wanted.
I felt profoundly human.
A mess, but in divine glory.
You could ask me the time,
And I would not know if it was 5 AM or 5 PM.
I started belching from the acidity,
From not having had lunch yet, despite it being so late.
I could feel the warmth of the wine-smell
Flowing from my mouth, like fire from a dragon.

Slowly, people began to come to the park.
I decided to get up. I decided to leave.
The sun was still there, but it was getting less bright outside.
I had power connections and the privilege to make a few clicks,
To arrange for a vehicle to drop me home.
But I did not do it.
There was a hill, and a long road, before I could reach home.
I walked up the hill.
Slow steps, because of the effects of the wine.
I climbed the hill steadily.
On the other side, I saw a shop.
I saw a packet of Doritos outside, for twenty rupees.
I looked at it.
Needless to say, my bank balance was not very happy.
But I started munching on the corn crisps nevertheless.
I strolled across the footpath in the evening sun.
I had befriended a security guard of a restaurant.
I offered him the Doritos, and I shared them with him.
He was grateful.
And I felt even more pleased.
I threw the empty packet into the trashcan.
I licked the remaining crisps,
And the powder of the chips,
From my three fingers.

At that moment, I did not think of my ex-female partners.
I did not desire their presence.
No, I did not think of any womanly comfort.
I felt deeply, truly free.
I did not need their sweet words, nor their warmth.

I passed by a church.
I heard the usual mass from outside, through the walls.
I heard the words:
“He took some wine, and took the chalice,
And gave it to his disciples, saying,
Take this, all of you, and drink of it...
He broke the bread... For this is my body...
Which shall be given up for you.”
And I could not help but shed a tear.
A tear from awe.
At that moment, I felt a voice from above.
It said, “You are my son, in whom I am well pleased.”
I was not certain.
Was it the effects of the wine, amplified by my dehydration?
Or was I just losing my mind?
As I reached the block of my home, I was perspiring.
I cleaned my spectacles with my sweaty shirt.
I looked at the purple flowers outside our house.
I saw many ants, walking in a frenzy on the footpath.
And I went home in stealth.
But the truth is, I was always feeling
Like I was at home.